

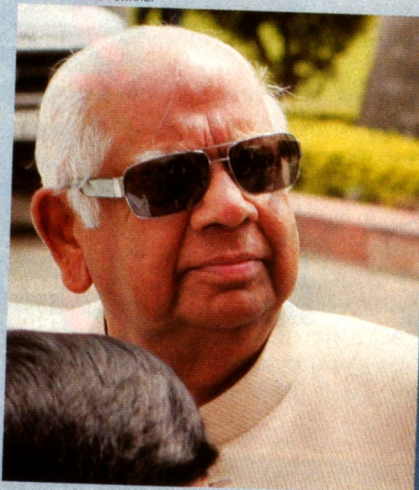
Expelled for Independence

The CPI(M) Politburo's expulsion of the loyal footsoldier may well bring to an end the career of a fine Parliamentarian

A parliamentarian since 1971, Somnath Chatterjee, even by the geriatric standards of the CPI(M), is a veteran. He has also won the best parliamentarian award. The post of the Speaker that he has occupied since 2004 was supposed to be the icing on the cake for the successful barrister from Kolkata. Ironically, it has turned out to be something that has actually cut the umbilical cord that linked this footsoldier and the party he has served for over four decades. Chatterjee had irked the CPI(M) top boss Prakash Karat when he refused to step down as the Lok Sabha Speaker following the party's withdrawal of support to the UPA Government.

Though the CPI(M) had publicly maintained that the Speaker was "free to take his own decision", it privately asked him to step down before the trust vote since it believed that it was on the basis of the UPA-Left alliance that Chatterjee was elected Speaker. The party constitution gives members the right to be heard before any action is taken. Last year, the party suspended Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan and his *bête noire* party Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan from the Politburo for engaging in factional feuds. Months later, the

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SWAN SONG: Chatterjee leaving Parliament after trust vote

suspensions were revoked. Chatterjee did not enjoy the privilege as the party fell back on clauses that allow it to summarily expel members involved in anti-party activities. During his tenure, he also invited the wrath of the NDA for "favouring treasury benches". The Left MPs then cited that during the first two years of the Government, Chatterjee admitted 78 call-attention motions and five adjournment motions compared to the 60 call-attention motions and five adjournment motions during the NDA's five-year reign.

In a letter to Karat, Chatterjee attributed his decision not to step down to his reluctance to vote with the BJP. It's a bogus claim. At least twice in the past, including the infamous vote against the Narasimha Rao Government in 1993 that gave rise to the JMM scandal, he voted with the BJP. Yet, his expulsion almost puts an end to a remarkable parliamentary career. Even the comrades will miss him.

by Shafi Rahman

private banking sector to 74 per cent FDI and stopped a legislation which would have allowed privatisation of government employees' pension funds. We have also been able to slow down the pace of implementation of neo-liberal policies," he said in the political and organisational report.

With Manmohan freeing himself from Karat's grip, the Government is expected to fasten reform initiatives stalled following the Left's intervention. "We have a majority. Therefore, we have to work with other parties to carry forward the reforms process," said Finance Minister Palaniappan Chidambaram. The nuclear deal is also back on the track with the Government deploying its ministers and top-ranking envoys on the 'charm NSG' mission.

Last week's events also brought to the fore the vulnerability of the Third Front allies. The CPI(M)'s chief partner in the new grouping, the TDP, saw two of its five MPs walking over to the UPA. Adikesavulu, a liquor baron with business interests across Andhra Pradesh, and M. Jagannath, the MP from Nagakurnool, shifted their allegiances as Naidu got himself busy forging the new front. Worse, the new Third Front's line-up consists of the BSP, TDP, JD(S) and AGP, all of whom have supped with the BJP at the state or national level in the last decade or so. As such it

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is doubtful if any of them actually attains the qualifying mark set by Karat: of being parties with impeccable secular credentials.

It's not just the luxury of the backseat drive the Left will miss. It has suddenly been forced out of the national stage without making major inroads outside West Bengal and Kerala which provided a bulk of its 59 MPs in the 14th Lok Sabha. But its governments in both the states are flitting from disaster to disaster, leaving even dyed-in-the-wool leftists wondering if they'll be able to match even half the 2004 tally.

Big Brother will have to depend on crumbs thrown its way by Mayawati in Uttar Pradesh and Chandrababu Naidu in Andhra Pradesh to make up even some of that expected huge shortfall. The story of Karat's rise and rise may well turn out to a short, meteoric one followed by a loud thud.